

THE STORY SPINE CARD

Every story runs on one spine. Find yours, then ask the one question built for it.

The questioner's posture stays constant from story to story. The question changes based on what the story is pressing on. Most stories run on one of three spines — pursuit, holding, or loss. Find the one your protagonist is on below, then ask the question. Refuse the first answer. Wait for the third.

THE PURSUIT SPINE

Surface answer: *The protagonist is chasing something — a goal, a truth, a person, a resolution. The surface reason is almost always mission-focused: justice, love, survival, duty.*

THE QUESTION

What does this character believe will happen to them personally if they succeed?

Not to the mission — to them. Success terrifies certain characters as much as failure does. Find out which kind of character this is, and refuse the first answer.

THE HOLDING SPINE

Surface answer: *The protagonist is trying to keep something together — a family, a version of themselves, a story they've been telling. The surface reason is sacrifice, endurance, love.*

THE QUESTION

What would this character have to admit if they stopped holding on?

The holding is never really about the thing being held. It's always about what stopping would mean. Locate that meaning, and refuse the first answer.

THE LOSS SPINE

Surface answer: *The protagonist has lost something — a person, a belief, a version of their life. The surface reason is grief, absence, longing.*

THE QUESTION

What is this character still protecting by keeping the loss alive?

Loss is rarely passive. People organize their identity around it, use it to explain their choices, allow it to justify what they won't become. Find the structure the loss is serving.

THE PATTERN UNDERNEATH ALL THREE

The questioner never accepts the answer that completes the sentence the author already wrote in their head. The question you're looking for is the one that surprises you — the answer you didn't already have when you sat down. That surprise is the character arriving.

This is one question from a full method. Write Living Characters: A Fiction Writer's Masterclass teaches you to run it, and everything underneath it, with AI as your Socratic coach.